India’s policy towards the superpowers has greatly informed China. For instance, after the Sino–Soviet split in 1960 and the Sino–Indian war in 1962, India’s gradual drift into the orbit of the Soviet Union was a concern in Beijing. Today, Beijing wants to avoid India aligning with the United States.

China’s policy on India is also shaped by the potential threat India constitutes to stability on China’s western frontier, leading China to pursue various balancing strategies towards India. China shares an extensive border with India in the Himalayas, and large parts of this border are disputed. China is also concerned about India’s ability to use its links to the Tibetan exile movement to destabilise China’s most volatile western frontier. Naturally, the border issue is an important dimension in Sino–Indian relations. Yet an analysis of China’s policy on the border dispute with India has to go beyond achievements and setbacks at the negotiation table or the military posture at the actual border.[8] It has to incorporate measures taken by China to alleviate potential Indian pressure on the border, and this covers in particular China’s support to Pakistan but also its engagement with other countries or political movements in India’s neighbourhood.

The third main variable informing China’s India policy is its evolving geo-strategy. Geostrategy is the main geographic direction of a state’s foreign policy and “describes where a state concentrates its efforts by projecting military power and directing diplomatic activity.”[9] Geostrategy builds on geopolitics, and is as such influenced by shifts in the geographic distribution and strategic location of centres of resources and lines of communication. It follows from this that the geographic extent of a state’s interests is not limited to its home territory but encompasses areas with resources and trade routes vital to its survival.[10] Furthermore, geostrategy is shaped by the interactions and capabilities of geopolitical actors, states, and in particular great powers in their respective spheres of influence.[11] Whether India is at